

Project Proposal

Title

Design and Development of the PATNA Digital Platform: A Community-Driven Decision Intelligence System for Africa's Energy Transition

Submitted to

The Professional African Technical Network Advisory (PATNA) Initiative

1. Background and Rationale

PATNA has evolved from a network supporting African participation in maritime decarbonisation into a broader platform advancing inclusive energy transition and climate action across Africa.

As PATNA's mandate expands, its digital infrastructure must also evolve. The current website functions primarily as an information repository and does not yet support:

- structured onboarding of members across cohorts,
- sustained coordination and collaboration,
- systematic use of accumulated knowledge and insights, or
- scalable delivery of PATNA's decision-intelligence role.

To fulfil its strategic objectives, PATNA requires a purpose-built digital platform that reflects how it actually works: as a coordinator, synthesiser, and enabler of African-centred decision-making.

This project proposes the design and phased development of an integrated digital platform that supports PATNA's community, knowledge, and future decision-support functions.

2. Project Objectives

The project aims to:

- Align PATNA's digital presence with its evolving role as a decision-intelligence and coordination platform.
- Enable structured community engagement across PATNA's cohorts (Academic, Policy, Industry, Civil Society).
- Transform PATNA's growing body of knowledge into a usable, decision-oriented system, rather than a static library.
- Establish a robust data foundation that supports future AI-enabled decision support.
- Improve operational efficiency, governance, and institutional continuity.

3. Scope of Work and Phased Delivery

The project will be delivered in two structured phases, balancing ambition with realism.

Phase 1 (Month 1): Platform MVP

- Redesigned public website aligned with PATNA's strategy
- Unified Insights system (blog, briefs, reports, event outputs)
- Community onboarding flow (expression of interest → interview → approval → onboarding)
- Member profiles, cohort assignment, and tagging
- Community spaces (cohorts, thematic constituencies, working groups)
- Moderation and role-based governance tools

Outcome: A fully functional platform supporting community engagement and knowledge sharing.

Phase 2 (Month 2): AI-Ready Integration

- Structuring and indexing of PATNA knowledge assets
- Initial RAG-based AI decision-support integration
- Role-aware AI interactions grounded in PATNA-approved content
- Testing, refinement, and documentation

Outcome: An augmented platform that supports sense-making and learning without replacing human judgement.

4. Platform Governance and Design Principles

The platform is designed around:

- Cohort-based identity, allowing members to belong to multiple cohorts
- Tag-driven structure, enabling cross-cutting collaboration (e.g. SIDS, LDCs, oil-producing states)
- Role-based permissions, ensuring clarity between members, cohort leads, moderators, and administrators
- Human-first systems, with AI introduced only after governance and data foundations are in place

5. Expected Outcomes

By the end of the project, PATNA will have:

- A credible, modern website aligned with its strategic direction
- A structured, moderated community platform
- A unified Knowledge & Insights Hub supporting real decision processes
- A future-ready data model for AI-enabled decision support
- Improved engagement with members, partners, and funders
- Stronger institutional memory and continuity

6. Strategic Value to PATNA

This project:

- Makes PATNA's value proposition visible and operational
- Strengthens Africa-centred coordination in global climate and energy processes
- Reduces reliance on ad-hoc communication channels
- Builds a scalable foundation for future products and services
- Enhances funder confidence through system-level capability

7. Implementation Approach

The project will follow an iterative, co-design approach, working closely with:

- PATNA Secretariat
- Cohort Leads
- Selected members and partners

Key principles include:

- simplicity over feature-heaviness,
- clarity over speed,
- governance before automation.

8. Budget and Cost Narrative

Overall Budget

Total project cost (2 months): ~~¥~~12,000,000

- Phase 1 – Platform MVP: ~~¥~~6,000,000
- Phase 2 – AI Integration: ~~¥~~6,000,000

Cost Rationale (Funder-Friendly Narrative)

This cost reflects the design and development of a purpose-built institutional platform, not a generic website.

The work includes community governance design, cohort-based onboarding, knowledge architecture, and a future-ready data model that enables AI-supported decision intelligence. These elements are essential to PATNA's role as a coordination and decision-support platform, and go well beyond standard web development.

Comparable platforms developed externally would cost significantly more, particularly given the level of domain-specific design, governance logic, and strategic integration required.

By building locally with a lean, highly focused team, PATNA achieves strong value-for-money while retaining full ownership, adaptability, and institutional control over the platform.

The phased approach also ensures that:

- early value is delivered quickly,
- risk is managed, and

- future enhancements can be introduced responsibly.

9. Risk Management

Risk

Mitigation

Over-complexity

Phased delivery; AI introduced only after foundations

Low community uptake

Cohort-led onboarding and moderation

Content sprawl

Unified publishing system with tagging discipline

Governance overload

Clear role-based permissions

10. Conclusion

This project positions PATNA as more than a network or repository of outputs. It establishes PATNA as a living decision-intelligence system capable of supporting Africa's energy transition and climate action over time.

The proposed investment is modest relative to its strategic value and creates a durable foundation for PATNA's next phase of growth and impact.

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